THE BATTLE OF TARANTO

Admiral Sir Andrew Cunningham approved a bold plan for a night attack by the Fleet Air Arm upon the Italian naval base at Taranto. For the first time in history a naval attack would use only planes, launching them from offshore aircraft carriers. The raid was originally scheduled for Trafalgar Day, October 21, and was to involve the carriers *Eagle* and *Illustrious*. However, fire damage to one ship and structural damage to the other delayed the action. Eventually it was decided to go ahead with *Illustrious* only, bolstered by the transfer of five aircraft from *Eagle*.

THE AIRCRAFT

It was a peculiarity of the Fleet Air Arm that its carriers were superb but its aircraft were obsolescent. The raid was carried out by slow-moving Fairey Swordfish, two-seater biplanes that had first entered service in 1936 and were affectionately known as "Stringbags." Escorted by cruisers and destroyers, *Illustrious* approached within striking range of Taranto on the evening of November 11, flying off two waves of 12 and nine Swordfish an hour apart. Half the aircraft were armed with torpedoes and the rest with bombs. The torpedoes were used against the six battleships and three cruisers moored in Taranto's outer harbor, while the bombs were dropped on the smaller ships in the inner harbor.

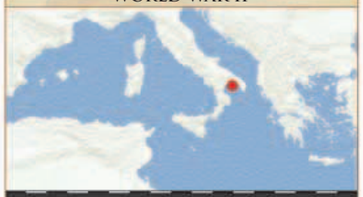


Fairey Swordfish
British Fairey Swordfish torpedo-bombers used modified torpedoes dropped from a low height to attack the Italian fleet at Taranto.

THE OUTCOME

The Italians were well prepared for an aerial attack. The Swordfish flew into an inferno of anti-aircraft fire, some keeping so low their wheels touched the sea. Their torpedoes had been skillfully adapted to run in the shallow harbor waters and explode beneath the torpedo nets protecting the capital ships. Five struck home, hitting the battleships *Vittorio Veneto*, *Caio Duilio*, and *Conte di Cavour*. A cruiser in the inner harbor was badly damaged by bombs. Remarkably only two Swordfish were shot down during the conflict. For this trivial cost, the Fleet Air Arm succeeded in halving the Italian battleship strength in a single night. *Vittorio Veneto* and *Caio Duilio* were recommissioned the following year, but *Cavour* was never salvaged.

WORLD WAR II



THE BATTLE OF TARANTO

Date	November 11–12, 1940
Location	Taranto, southern Italy
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	ITALY

COMMANDERS

Sir Andrew Cunnngham	**Inigo Campioni**

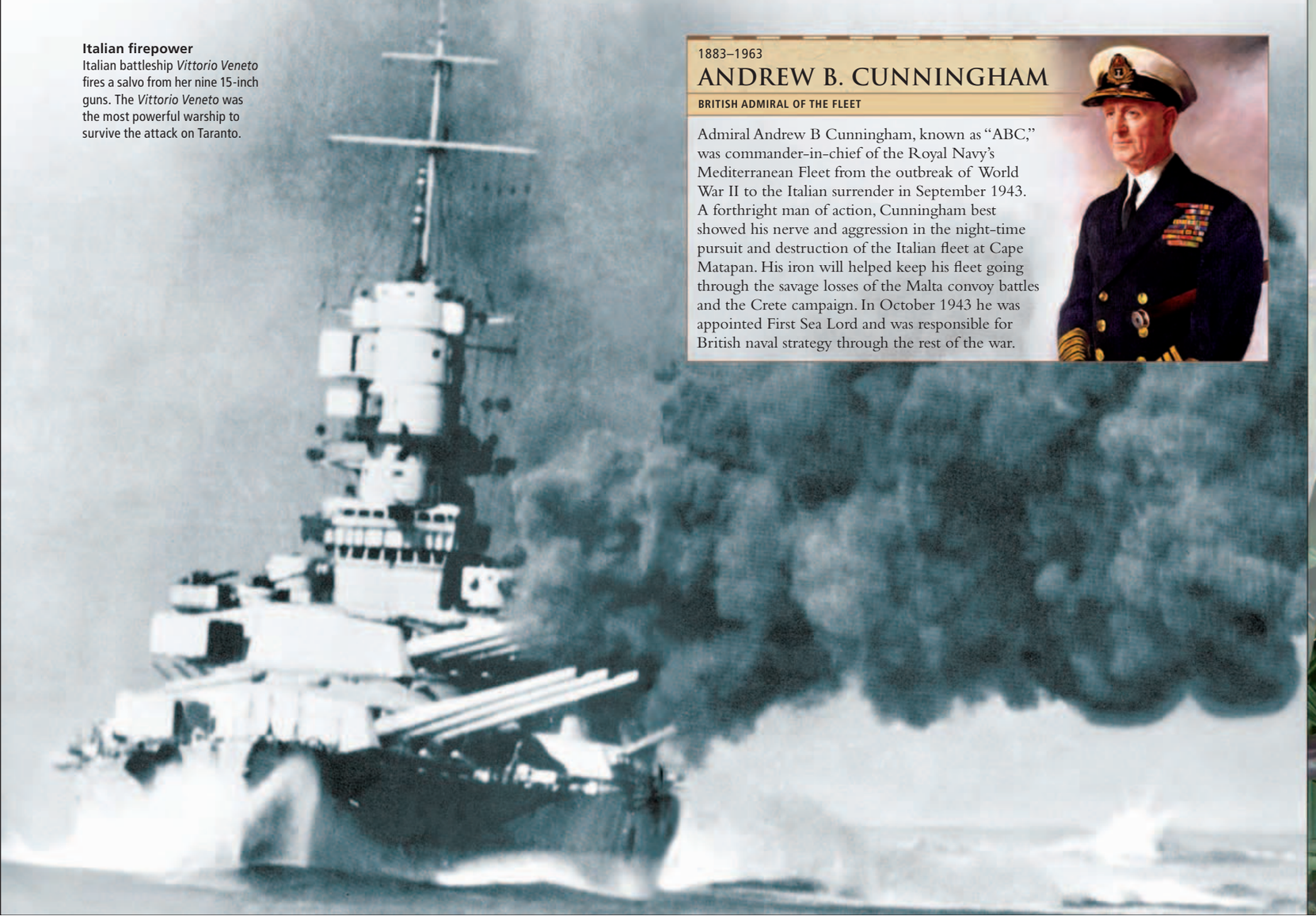
FORCES

Ships: 1 carrier, 4 cruisers, 4 destroyers	**Ships:** 6 battleships, 9 cruisers, 17 destroyers

LOSSES

Men: 2 **Ships:** none **Aircraft:** 2	**Men:** 59 **Ships:** 1 battleship sunk, 2 battleships and 1 cruiser disabled

The victory tilted the balance of power in the Mediterranean in favor of the Allies. Any Italian ships that survived the attack were moved further north to Naples and La Spezia.



Italian firepower
Italian battleship *Vittorio Veneto* fires a salvo from her nine 15-inch guns. The *Vittorio Veneto* was the most powerful warship to survive the attack on Taranto.

1883–1963

ANDREW B. CUNNINGHAM

BRITISH ADMIRAL OF THE FLEET

Admiral Andrew B Cunningham, known as "ABC," was commander-in-chief of the Royal Navy's Mediterranean Fleet from the outbreak of World War II to the Italian surrender in September 1943. A forthright man of action, Cunningham best showed his nerve and aggression in the night-time pursuit and destruction of the Italian fleet at Cape Matapan. His iron will helped keep his fleet going through the savage losses of the Malta convoy battles and the Crete campaign. In October 1943 he was appointed First Sea Lord and was responsible for British naval strategy through the rest of the war.